



N. Korean soldiers captured, Kyiv says

Wounded pair caught in Russia being questioned on Pyongyang’s war role

BY SIOBHÁN O’GRADY

KYIV — Ukraine has begun questioning two wounded North Korean soldiers captured from the battlefield in Russia’s Kursk region, authorities said Saturday, the first time Kyiv has confirmed detaining North Korean troops since they were deployed late last year to assist Russian forces in their war on Ukraine.

“Two soldiers, though wounded, survived and were transported to Kyiv, where they are now communicating with the Security Service of Ukraine,” President Volodymyr Zelensky wrote in an Instagram post with photos of the prisoners. “This was not an easy task: Russian forces and other North Korean military personnel usually execute their wounded to erase any evidence of North Korea’s involvement in the war against Ukraine.”

“As with all prisoners of war, these two North Korean soldiers are receiving the necessary medical assistance,” he wrote. He said he had instructed security officials to grant journalists access to the prisoners. “The world needs to know the truth about what is happening.”

Ukraine’s internal security service, the SBU, said the capture

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Fighting rages: Kyiv sees in Kursk a bargaining chip for peace. **A16**

Big Tech now giving millions to Trump

Vilified by him for years, Silicon Valley executives line up to mend fences

BY DREW HARWELL

On Jan. 7, 2021, when Meta suspended Donald Trump’s Facebook account after the U.S. Capitol riot, company chief Mark Zuckerberg said the risks of allowing the then-president to keep using the service after inciting a “violent insurrection” were “simply too great.” Trump would go on to blame Zuckerberg for his 2020 election loss, threatening him with life in prison.

On Tuesday, exactly four years later, Zuckerberg sang a different tune. As part of an announcement shared first with Fox News, Zuckerberg said that Trump’s win in the November election marked “a cultural tipping point” on speech and that he was terminating Facebook’s “politically biased” fact-checkers, who he said had destroyed public trust. Asked at a news conference that day whether Zuckerberg’s move was a response to Trump’s threats against him, Trump said, “Yeah, probably.”

Meta’s about-face on Trump reflects a broader pattern in Silicon Valley.

SEE TRUMP ON A4

The Sunday Take: Biden’s choice to run again will shape legacy. **A2**

L.A. in flames: ‘Apocalyptic. Surreal.’



DAVID RYDER/REUTERS

Years of efforts to avert disaster were not enough

BY ANNA PHILLIPS,
MOLLY HENNESSY-FISKE,
EVAN HALPER
AND JOSHUA PARTLOW

In Los Angeles’s chaparral-covered ecosystem, wildfires in the mountains are an annual ritual. But when those fires leaped into residential neighborhoods last week, killing at least 11 people and destroying thousands of homes, the city suddenly found itself in survival mode.

A critical question became why the largest city in California, a state that has spent years fortifying itself against wildfires, couldn’t stop the fires this time. State regulations required residents in high-risk neighborhoods to create vegetation-free buffers around their homes. California had invested billions of dollars to reduce the amount of woody fuel for fires to burn. It boasted the largest firefighting force in the nation.

Yet within a few days, decades-old communities and beloved landmarks were gone, and residents were left asking why.

Experts said several key factors — including urban sprawl, a resistance to clearing vegetation around homes, and a water system that’s not designed to combat multiple major blazes at

SEE UNPREPARED ON A9

Power grid: Some lines had juice despite “red-flag” conditions. **A8**



MELINA MARA/THE WASHINGTON POST

FROM TOP: Smoke from the Palisades Fire rises above downed power lines and other debris Saturday in Los Angeles’ Pacific Palisades neighborhood. Residents of the city’s Brentwood neighborhood grow frustrated waiting in line to reach their homes to retrieve their valuables.

Thousands of razed homes jolt market already in crisis

BY DANIEL WU
AND RACHEL SIEGEL

LOS ANGELES — LaNiece Carpenter fled with her siblings, parents and pets from her Altadena home at 4 a.m. Wednesday as flames raced across the tops of the hills behind them. Now, with the family home turned to ash,

she must confront the question facing every Angeleno displaced by the fires: Where to now?

She doesn’t want to leave the city she grew up in, but it might be too costly to return. “It is an impossible decision either way,” Carpenter, 30, said.

Los Angeles County, the nation’s most populous, faced an

unprecedented housing crisis even before the past week’s fires destroyed an estimated 12,000 structures, including thousands of homes, and forced mass evacuations. The disaster has already been pegged as the costliest blaze in U.S. history, with analysts projecting total economic losses of

SEE HOUSING ON A10

How to help: Agencies rush in for humans and animals alike. **A10**

Live streams: Homes broadcast their ruin as owners watched. **A11**

CHAOS REIGNS FROM MOUNTAINS TO SEA

Angelenos dig deep amid loop of fresh hells

BY REIS THEBAULT

LOS ANGELES — Disaster is in the air. It clouds the skies, it sears the eyes, it lodges in the lungs. Most of all, it weighs on the heart.

For those who have lost it all, the pain is acute.

But even for the lucky ones, the millions of Angelenos who are miles away, the fires are still inescapable, an ever-present ache.

Smoke veils the Hollywood sign, ash falls on the Walk of Fame. School is canceled, kids are home. Businesses closed, Lakers games postponed. Residents all over the vast metropolis are coughing and fearful. From the television to the group chats, danger and destruction plays on a loop.

Sundered and surrounded by flames, it’s hard to breathe, hard to work, hard to know what comes next.

Nearly 200,000 people have already evacuated, and many more are keeping an anxious eye on every new alert — their packed bags by the door just in case. More than 12,000 structures have been destroyed across the county, and just about every-

SEE CHAOS ON A12

Dry hydrants: Reports spark outrage and finger-pointing. **A14**

New agony for Israel’s hostage families in whipsaw Gaza talks

BY GERRY SHIH
AND HAZEM BALOUSHA

RAHAT, ISRAEL — As Biden administration officials spoke optimistically last week about Israel and Hamas nearing a Gaza ceasefire deal, Hamas officials leaked a list of 34 hostages they were willing to release. But for at least

one of the captives on the list, it was already too late.

The Israeli military said Wednesday that it had found and recovered the remains of Youssef Ziyadne, a 53-year-old Bedouin man who was taken by Hamas fighters on Oct. 7. It’s not clear exactly when his body was found, how he died, or how long he had

been dead.

The episode followed the familiar cycle of hope and despair that has whipsawed Israel’s hostage families — and defined the ceasefire negotiations — for the past 15 months. Even now, as U.S. and Arab mediators push for a deal before President-elect Donald Trump’s inauguration on Jan.

20, few hostage families have any faith left in the process. And the case of the Ziyadnes, they say, only sharpened the agonizing, long-standing question of how many of their loved ones are still alive.

Early Monday, Mazin Abu Siam, a close friend of the Ziyadne family, saw the list of hostages

published in an Arabic-language news outlet and forwarded it excitedly to Youssef’s brother Nawaf. Less than 72 hours later, he received word that Youssef’s remains had been found in an underground tunnel in southern Gaza.

“We had hope that we would

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METRO
D.C. area is on alert after bird flu found in poultry in Maryland, Delaware.

SPORTS
From putrid to playoffs, the Commanders made all the right moves.



TRAVEL
Tulum, Mexico, used to be for backpackers. Now it’s “boho-chic.”

BOOK WORLD
“Mothers and Sons” is a hypnotic look at people running from the past.



BUSINESS
Women are putting off retirement and changing the face of U.S. labor.

ARTS & STYLE
“The Brutalist” movie gets architecture wrong, but it gets genius right.

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